

Week 9/10: GitHub Pages Workshop

Web Presentation, Accessibility, and Sustainability

HIST 501D - Digital History

April 7, 2026

Web Presentation Is Part of the Argument

Interface is not just the style or look added as an afterthought to a project. Design features, functionality, and intellectual content must be fully integrated. [Drucker -- Ch. 10]

Interface is Intellectual Work, NOT Decoration

- the site is part of the scholarly argument, not just a container for it
- It tells visitors what matters, in what order, and for whom
- A DH website is a form of historical interpretation

From Sketch to Prototype

Stage	Fidelity	What it is
Wireframe	Low	Paper sketch — layout only, no color or content
Mockup	Medium	Static visual — looks real, not interactive
Prototype	High	Working build — loads in a browser, links function
Final Product	High	Polished, tested, and ready for public use

Today: build a working shell in class → then begin to wireframing (design/sketch)

Today's Goals

- Build a four-page GitHub Pages site as a working shell
- Embed and interpret one visualization from an earlier assignment
- Set up a placeholder planning page for sketches and design notes
- Set up a sustainability page for future use
- After class: sketch the interface on paper and update the planning page

Repository vs. Website

What would a GitHub site be for if a project website is public-facing? What goes in the repository vs. what goes on the website?

Repository

- stores files, code, notebooks, drafts, and data
- explains preservation and sustainability strategy
- useful for process and version history
- may make sense to you but not to a first-time visitor

Website

- presents the project to a public audience
- frames the research question and methods
- interprets evidence instead of just storing it
- makes content accessible to non-technical users

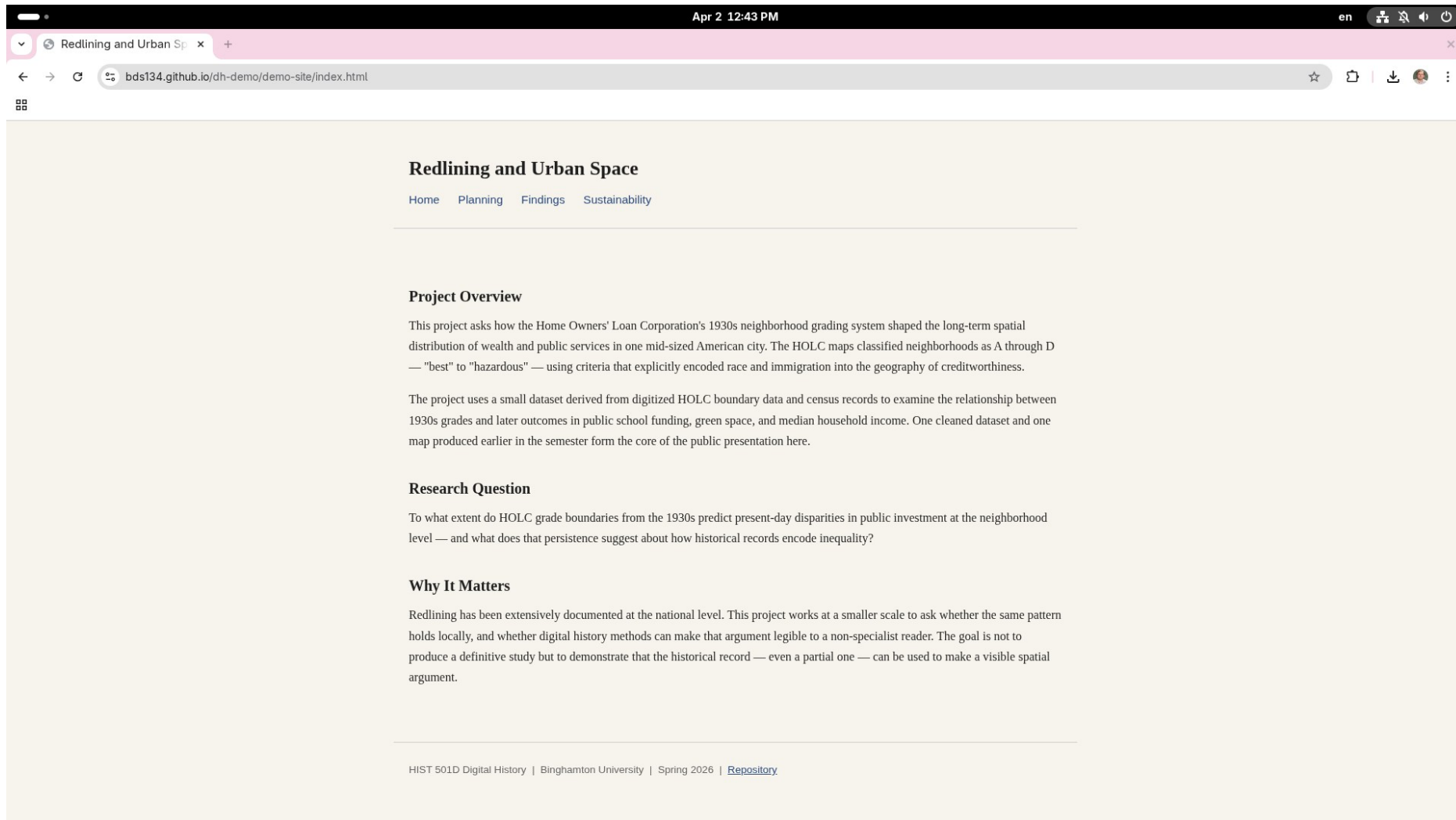
Why a Static Site?

Digital systems are platforms layered on top of each other. The more layers, the more can break [Owens Ch. 2]

This assignment asks you to build a static site rather than a dynamic one. What are the advantages of a static site for a student project?

- Fewer moving parts
- Easier to understand and maintain
- Easier to preserve than a database-driven system
- Enough for many student and scholarly project sites
- Practices 'minimal computing' []
- Good fit for GitHub Pages

A Working Demo Site



Demo site home page <https://bds134.github.io/dh-demo/demo-site/index.html>

The Smallest Useful Site

- `index.html` for project overview
- `planning.html` for interface sketches and design decisions
- `findings.html` for one visualization, with interpretation
- `sustainability.html` for platform documentation
- `style.css` for readable, consistent design
- `assets/` folder for images or downloadable files

Designing for Your Audience

- Who is the intended visitor for your site?
- A specialist? A general public reader? A future researcher?
- How does that change your design?

Testing with real users

Write specific use cases linked to specific profiles or personae of visitors. Who will use the site? Be specific about their goals, background, needs, behaviors, and abilities. Write a step-by-step scenario for a persona from the moment they arrive at the landing page. [Drucker Chapter 10]

ASSIGNMENT SEQUENCE

Five-Part Sequence

- Part 1: build the GitHub Pages site shell (all students)
- Part 2: sketch the interface on paper and update the planning page with design notes (all students)
- Part 3: develop the website as a working prototype
- Part 4: user testing — design questions for your site; two classmates test and respond (all students)
- Part 5: write a sustainability and preservation document (4-credit students only)

Who Needs to Complete What?

2 credits

- complete the GitHub Pages website
- participate in user testing (write testing questions; test two classmates' sites)

4 credits

- build the GitHub Pages site as a working prototype
- participate in user testing (write testing questions; test two classmates' sites)
- complete sustainability document (due April 20)
- use the site as part of the prototype and later project stages

User Testing Assignments

4-credit students — each site has two testers:

Ryan: tested by Rachel and Shalima

Alfie: tested by Ryan and Shalima

Rachel: tested by Ryan and Alfie

Shalima: tested by Alfie and Rachel

2-credit students — each site has two testers:

Musa: tested by Killian and Yaoyuan

Killian: tested by Yaoyuan and Musa

Yaoyuan: tested by Musa and Killian

Accessibility Pass

- Add meaningful alt text to images
- Use descriptive headings
- Make links understandable out of context
- Check contrast and readability
- Make sure the site still works on a narrow screen

Check It with WAVE

- Go to **<https://wave.webaim.org>**
- Paste your live GitHub Pages URL and run the check
- WAVE overlays icons directly on your page — errors in red, alerts in yellow
- Fix every red error before submitting
- Work through the yellow alerts where you can

Sustainability

- Why this platform?
- Which files are essential?
- What data or media dependencies matter?
- What would a future user need to understand or reuse the project?
- artifactual, informational, or folkloric preservation?